

Question ID: c468db1c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

A group of ecologists led by Axel Mithöfer at the Max Planck Institute for Chemical Ecology in Germany examined the defensive responses of two varieties of the sweet potato _____ TN57, which is known for its insect resistance, and TN66, which is much more susceptible to pests.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. plant.
- B. plant;
- C. plant
- D. plant:

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”) and to introduce the following elaboration on the specific varieties of sweet potato plants that were examined.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “TN57.” Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”) with appropriate punctuation.